

# *Harvest Fest*

Saelunere, Episode One

Parvo, in the year 756

v1.0

The last day of autumn, and Oblong Square was full from one row of stalls to the other.

Harvest Fest is the festival of plenty, so the square had been given over to everything the month had grown too much of, and the crowd moved through it slowly, buying and arguing and eating in the street. Lamps had been strung between the upper windows. Behind it all the Stacks went up in their piled and leaning way, house on house around the great chimney, every window lit, so the northern edge of the square looked like a cliff with a town spilled down its face.

There were five people in that square who did not know one another, and by midnight they would be the only ones left in it.

Billiam had the best seat and it had cost him nothing: a stack of crates against the north wall, four high, from the top of which the whole festival lay open below him like something set out on a table. He was Darkin, purple-skinned, with a good length of horn curling back off his head, and dressed like anyone else in the Stacks. He sat with his knees up and a skewer in one hand and watched, which was the entire plan for the evening. Nothing anywhere was wrong. Nobody was watching anybody.

Down in the crowd, Lark was taking her time. She was Aela, and small even for that, a hundred and fifty centimetres of her, with a round freckled face and fluffy dark hair cut off below the ears with one pale streak at the front. Everything she wore was earth-coloured and worn without being ragged, and all of it covered her: baggy trousers, a big light scarf, tight bandage wraps up both forearms and another across one cheek. She moved through a packed square the way you move through one when nobody sees you coming, watching shoulders and reading the gaps before they opened.

She had come to hear Theo speak. She had caught him mentioning it in passing at one of his meetings the week before and had held onto it, because he was a man she admired and because he had been kind to her at times when there had not been much of that going spare. The stage at the far end stood empty. There was an hour yet.

Then a lute started up in one of the inns, and it drew two more of them in.

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The trick with the man who kept the Plumb and Bob, a big harassed innkeeper named Harl Mott, was to ask him for something while he was too busy to argue.

Aeska had spent an hour in there buying nothing and drinking what he was given, and he made his approach at the exact moment the place went from busy to impossible. He was Aela, and dressed carefully to look like everybody else in the room, and his hair and his face both carried the kind of mess that a man either does not notice or arranges. A drink came sliding down the bar to him unasked.

“Aeska. You going to be playing tonight?”

“If that’s what you want me to do, boss. You know my rates.” He let it sit. “And you know tonight’s a big night.”

“Alright. You can get up there whenever you want, mate. You know the drill. Fifty per cent to the house, you keep the rest, and you’ll have a room here tonight if you want it.” Harl leaned over towards the corner stage, where four revellers had colonised the boards. “Oi! Get off the fucking stage!”

“Boss. Don’t you think tonight’s a special night? I should get a bit more. Look at all these people. Look at everyone outside. You know what my music can do. I can bring in more than this.”

A pause about the length of a held breath.

“Alright, alright. Sixty. Forty to the house.”

Aeska finished the drink before he went up, because a man who runs to the

stage looks like a man who needs the work. Then he played, and played well, to a room that was not listening, which is most rooms on a festival night.

Two people came in during the first half hour and he noticed both without deciding to. He would learn both their names before the night was over.

The first was a Darkin about his own age: average height, short dark hair, small black horns curling back along the skull, long sleeves in a hot room. He got four feet past the door, stopped dead behind two men the size of loading cranes, and then worked his way along the wall to the bar with the patience of somebody used to being shorter than the crowd. That was Calder, who had come in for the music and stayed for a beer he did not particularly want. He had six days of work behind him and had come out that night for the specific pleasure of being nobody in a crowd, and it was working.

The second was the small Aela in the pale scarf, and she asked for water.

"Just water? It's Harvest Fest. You sure that's all you're having tonight?"

"I don't want to spend too much money. Water's fine."

Harl was in the middle of another order. He ducked under the bar anyway, came up with a water, and slid it across. "No charge. I'm feeling generous."

"Thank you. Have a good night. Good luck."

Lark watched him move off down the bar, and noticed again the peg below his left knee and the rhythm his whole body had built around it. She had been drinking in this room long enough that he knew her name and poured for her without asking, and in all that time she had never got one word out of him about what he had been before he stood behind this bar. Whatever it was, he had put it down and walked away from it.

An hour in, with a single mark in his pocket, Aeska was cut off mid-song by Harl banging a tankard with a stick until the room shut up.

"Right. A mate of mine. Theo. Some of you know him, he's a regular. He's doing a talk outside and he told me I had to chuck all of yous out so you'd listen to it. So we're closed till he's done. And you better go and listen, because I'll be watching."

Calder put his drink down on the bar.

He knew a Theo. He knew exactly one, and it did not occur to him for a moment that it might be a different one.

That his friend was mixed up in politics was not news. Theo had been talking that way for as long as Calder had known him, on rooftops and over drinks and at every opportunity in between. That he was standing on a stage outside this door tonight, in front of the whole square, was.

Calder picked the drink back up, because he had paid for it, and went out with the grumbling crowd, and found that he was grinning.



Two streets away Theo Blackwood was walking too fast and asking about his notes for the third time.

“You’ve got the script? You’ve got the notes?”

“You’ll be fine,” Felix said.

“I’ve been practising, but I don’t think I’m going to remember everything, you know?”

Felix had the satchel, and there was far too much in it. Theo had written out more paper than any man could use in an hour on a stage, and had then asked for all of it to be brought, so Felix had brought all of it. He was a big Darkin, dark blue, bearded, with a long sweep of horn, and dressed better than anyone he was likely to meet in Oblong Square that night.

He had been Theo’s secretary for a year, near enough. That was not why he was in this street. Theo had gone out of his way to say so when he asked, and had said it twice, and had used the word *friend* both times.

“Okay. Good. Good. Right. I’m glad you’re here. Look, this is a big thing for me. And I don’t know how it’s going to go. So I appreciate you helping me out on this one.”

Felix looked at him properly, the way you do when someone says a thing like that. Theo was nervous, and Theo was always a little nervous, and underneath it there was nothing at all to find. The same warmth. The same slightly over-bright friendliness he brought to a corridor at the guild. Nothing was hiding behind it.

“I don’t think there’s going to be any major trouble or anything,” Theo said as they came into the noise. “I haven’t seen any enforcers or anyone around in the square. It’s Harvest Fest, right? Everyone’s going to be chill.”

“I also think so.”

There was an empty patch of ground behind the stage where nobody had thought to stand. Theo went up the steps into it and looked out at a square that had filled to its walls, and people shouted his name, not many but enough, and glad, the way you shout at somebody you know. In the doorway of the Plumb and Bob, Harl leaned on the frame with his arms folded and nodded once.

Out in the crowd, Calder was trying to reach the front so that Theo would see him, and was failing. He put his shoulder in and said excuse me and worked forward, and five minutes later he stopped and found that he was further from the stage than when he had started. He was thirty or forty feet back with the whole square between himself and his friend, and he laughed at himself where nobody could hear it. Lark had done better, slipping down the thin edge of the crowd to within ten feet of the boards.

Theo cleared his throat, and moved his hand, and his voice came out over all of them at three times its size.

“Friends. It’s great to see so many of you here. Even if half of you only turned up for the half price drinks at the Plumb and Bob.”

The laugh went through the square, and from the doorway Harl bellowed, genuinely outraged, “What? There’s no half price drinks! You’re paying for that, Theo!” and the laugh became the other kind, the big one, the one that means a crowd has decided it likes you.

“Harvest Fest is the last day of the autumn month. We’re here to celebrate plenty. Abundance. But who out of all of you can say that they actually have abundance? Who here finds themselves overflowing with riches, able to pay what they owe, put something away for the future?”

Nobody laughed at that. There was a low grumbling agreement instead, which is the sound of a crowd finding itself in a sentence.

“These are harsh times, everyone, and we all know it. But us, the people here in the Stacks, in the Core, even down in the Bellows, we don’t get to have a say in how those times fall on us.” He paused, and it was clear he had practised the next part and worried about it. “I can’t deny that the guilds have done great things for this city. I’m part of a guild myself, and I understand the value they bring. When the fate of humanity rested on their shoulders, they stood up and took the brunt of it. They did great work. But that was over thirty years ago.”

*Twenty-eight*, Calder thought, at the back of a crowd, before he could stop himself. *It is twenty-eight years, Theo. It is the one number everybody knows.*

“So I’m bringing to you today a new way. A new idea. Where all Parvozians get a say. A vote, for the future of Parvo. This would be a vote for our leadership. A vote for everything that we can expect to want from the-”

There was no warning sound. There was a man speaking, and then a noise like a hammer coming through a wall from the far side, and Theo Blackwood’s chest opened.

He went backwards off the stage and out of sight, and the amplified sentence stopped in the middle of a word.

Then the square came apart.

There was a moment first, a bad one, where nothing happened at all. A thousand people stood still with their faces turned up at the stage and did not understand what they had just seen. Somebody laughed, once, the wrong kind. Then a woman near the front started screaming and did not stop, and that was the permission, and the whole square broke.

It was not like people running. It was like the ground tilting. Bodies went past in both directions and then all in one, and the noise stopped being voices

and turned into one flat roar with edges on it. The strung lamps swung on their wires. A stall went over somewhere at the back with a month's surplus under it and nobody stopped. People fell and were stood on and got up. A man went past with a child held above his head in both arms. An elbow caught Calder across the jaw and was gone before he could turn to see whose it was.

None of them knew where the shot had come from. That was what was driving it. Every one of them was running out of a place where a man had been opened up in front of them by something nobody had seen or heard, and what they wanted was walls, and a roof, and anything at all between themselves and the open sky.

Four people went towards the stage instead, and had to fight the whole square to do it.

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Felix reached him first, having been standing behind the stage when Theo came down off it.

"Theo. Theo, stay with us." He had hold of him by then, both hands, and did not appear to know what to do with either of them. "Stay alive."

Lark was over the balustrade and down the far side a moment later, and she got her palms flat on his chest and began to cast before she had let herself look at what she was doing.

It was a healing she had done a hundred times on cuts and burns and one broken wrist. You lay your hands on and you give, and there is a warmth that starts in your own forearms and travels, and under your palms the light gathers and goes in and the body takes it and closes. She could feel it leaving her exactly as it always did. *Mister Theodore*, she was saying. *Mister Theodore*. She did it again, and a third time, and the light went into him and found nothing to work on and simply stopped, the way water stops when you pour it into sand.

"Maybe he should get to a hospital." Felix said it to her, because she was the one with light coming out of her hands and he had decided that made her the person to say it to. "Or something."

Calder had to get through the crowd to reach them, and the crowd was going the other way. He put his shoulder down and pushed into it, got turned around twice, lost his line and found it again, and came round the corner of the stage scanning the rooftops as he went. Somewhere in the middle of that, a layer of

thickened air settled itself over his skin,<sup>1</sup> a finger's width off it and cold at the edges. He did not remember casting it.

He knelt on the far side of the body and did the one thing he was reliably any use for, which is to look at a thing carefully.

The wound was not a puncture. Something had gone through Theo and taken part of him away with it, and the blood was not welling up out of it the way blood does when there is still a man working behind it. It was already out, on the boards and on Lark's knees and down in the seams between the cobbles. Calder made himself study the edges of it and work out what makes an opening of that shape, and the answer was nothing he had seen or read about. Not a bolt. Not one of the essence pistols that money carries about. Whatever had done it had arrived with something closer to the weight of a falling wall.

"It's too late," he said. "I'm sorry. It's too late."

Lark kept her hands where they were. She was not crying. She had gone somewhere past the place where crying happens, into the flat clear country on the other side of it, where a thing can be entirely visible and still refuse to be true.

"Can we help him?"

"I don't think so." Calder heard his own voice come out level, and disliked it. "I think it's too late. I'm sorry."

The three of them stayed like that for a while. Nobody had told them to move and there was nobody left in the square to tell them.

"Who would do this?" Lark said, eventually.

"No idea," Felix said.

"He was such a good guy..." Calder was not sure he had meant to say it out loud. "He was such a good guy."

"He was a great boss."

Calder looked up at him across the body. "Boss?"

"Yeah." Felix did not look up. "Boss."

And that was the first thing any of them learned about any of the others: that the well-dressed blue Darkin with his hands full of a dead man had worked for him.

Lark stood up in the middle of it and made herself think, because thinking was better than the other thing.

Theo had gone backwards, which meant the shot had come from in front. Not the Stacks behind the stage, then, but the other way, out over the heads of a crowd that was no longer there, towards the Core. She looked along that line and saw roofs and ledges and gutters and a hundred windows, and above all of it, standing

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<sup>1</sup>**Mage Armor.** A sheath of hardened air held a finger's width off the body. It turns blows and missiles about as well as plate and weighs nothing. Cast in advance, it lasts most of a day.

up out of the city with an unbroken view of the exact boards where a man had been asked to come and stand, four guild spires.

She put it in her memory the way you put a face there.

Billiam had not gone to the body at all. He had gone up a drainpipe on the east side to a second-floor balcony, because from up there he could see, and from up there he looked at every ledge and every dark shape across the whole square, twice, and found nobody. It frightened him more than a figure would have.

Somewhere north of them a bell started up, the general alarm, rung by somebody who had run far enough to find one.

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By the time the bell had been ringing a minute, Oblong Square was empty.

Not thinning. Empty. There were people out there who had drunk in the Plumb and Bob for fifteen years, who had bought Theo a drink, who had shouted his name from the doorway four minutes earlier, and every one of them had gone up the side streets and had not come back. Harl had his door shut and barred. The abandoned stalls stood along both long sides with the goods still out on them.

Billiam came down off the wall and crossed all that emptiness slowly, in no hurry, and reached the body about the time the others had run out of things to try.

Then somebody started shouting at them from the mouth of an alley, and it was the lute player.

"All of you. Get over here." Aeska had come out of the pub last and had gone nowhere near the stage. "The guards are on their way. They aren't coming to ask questions, they're coming to arrest somebody. They don't care whether you're the shooter. They're going to see four people standing over a dead body, and that will do."

"Who's that?" Billiam said. "Where the hell did he come from?"

Lark knew him. Not to speak to, but she had watched him play in that room a dozen times, and something in her simply decided, on no evidence at all, that a man she had seen on a stage was a man who could be trusted in an alley. She started towards him.

Calder did not. A stranger had appeared out of the dark shouting instructions at four people standing over a friend's body, and Calder had a strong general policy about strangers with instructions. He stayed where he was and looked at the man properly, the way you look at someone when you are deciding, and



what he got back was not what he expected. Whatever else the lute player was, he meant it. He was frightened and he was in a hurry and he was telling the truth.

“Do you want to be the one sitting there when they arrive,” Aeska called, “with a dead body in your hands? They’ll throw you in prison for this. They will not care whether you did it.”

Billiam did not move, because it was not right. You did not leave a man lying in a square on his own for whoever came next, and you certainly did not leave him because a stranger in an alley told you to.

What he did instead made very little sense, and he knew it made very little sense while he was doing it. He got his hands under Theo’s shoulders and began to draw him back across the boards, away from the open middle of the square, as though anywhere in Oblong Square that night was going to be better for him than anywhere else.

“What are you doing?” Lark had turned back. “Why are you touching him?”

“I’m trying to protect him.”

“From what?”

“I don’t know.” He did not stop. “I don’t know what I’m doing. I don’t know what’s going on.”

“I don’t know either. But maybe we should just wait.”

“That’s what I’m trying to do.”

And then something reached into Billiam’s own chest. He felt it very clearly: a soft warm sideways pull towards the opinion of a man he had never met, arriving with the shape of somebody else’s hand on it. He threw it off and looked up, and the lute player was still talking in exactly the same reasonable voice.

“That guy.” He was pointing, and his voice had gone up. “That guy over there. He’s trying to use magic on me.”

He was right. It had been a charm,<sup>2</sup> thrown in about four seconds because it was the only thing Aeska had that worked at that speed, and there was no version of the rest of the evening in which it was going to be forgotten.

“He’s only trying to get you away from here.” Lark had her hands up, one towards each of them, as though that would help. “It isn’t safe.”

“Well, I don’t see anyone here.”

He said it into a silence, and the silence answered him. Boots, from the north where the bell was. A lot of them, running, coming down towards the square.

“Do you hear that? They are not coming here to ask questions. Unless you want to spend the rest of your life in a cell, I suggest you come now.” And Aeska

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<sup>2</sup>**Charm Person.** A word and a small movement of the hand, and the person you are speaking to finds you reasonable. Not commanded and not owned, simply liked far past what you have earned.

turned and started to go, because he had done what he could and he was not going to die for it.

“He might be right.” Calder had his hands out, half towards Billiam and half towards nothing. “I want to stay with him too. But this was professional. Somebody has done this cleanly and left, and if the guards come round that corner and find four of us standing over him, we are what they take home. They will want somebody. We are somebody.”

“I can’t just let his body lie here.”

“We can’t do anything about it,” Lark said. “He’s gone.”

Lark got hold of his wrist. His hands were slick to the elbow and so were hers.

“Please. I think we should go.”

“Then you go.” Billiam did not look at her. “I’m going to stay here.”

Lark did not argue with him again. She got both hands round his wrist instead and put her whole weight into it, all hundred and fifty centimetres of her, and hauled.

She could not have carried him. She did not need to. He came off Theo’s shoulders in one long unwilling slide, still reaching back, and she kept walking backwards and dragging him with her the whole way to the alley while he swore at her.

She was much stronger than she looked. That was the last clear thing he thought for a while.

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They made the alley, all five of them, and tried to go quietly, and it did not work at all.

There is a version of that night in which five people slip away up a side street and nobody ever knows they were there. It was never available. They were a ridiculous group to look at, mismatched by height and dress and race, moving too slowly because two of them were still arguing, and every one of them had another man’s blood on their hands and up their forearms. They got as far as the mouth of the alley.

The enforcers came into the square behind them: two patrolmen and an officer, in black and gold, with the wheel-and-compass of the Guild of Engineers on the breast. Four of the five knew that uniform on sight.

Three of them. For a public killing on a festival night, of a man who wore the same colours they did.

“Hey! Stop!”

Lark stopped as though she had run into a wall. It was not a decision, and afterwards she could not account for it: a voice with authority in it said stop, and every part of her did, including the hand that had hold of Billiam. She let go of him without noticing.

Aeska did the exact opposite. He had been standing at Felix’s shoulder and he was already moving before the shout had finished, because whatever else happened in Oblong Square tonight, he could not be taken in by these men and have his name written down in a guild ledger.

“Plumb and Bob,” he said, close to Felix’s ear, on his way past. “If you get out of this. Plumb and Bob.”

Then he was gone down the alley at a flat run, and the other four were left standing in its mouth without him.

Billiam watched him go and understood nothing at all. A stranger had shouted at him, cast a spell on him, argued with him over a body, told him he was about to be arrested, and then bolted the instant the guards actually arrived. He stood exactly where he was, because he could not think of a single thing to do that would not make it worse.

Calder looked hard at the three men crossing the square, hoping for a face he knew. In a city with as many enforcers as this one there was no reason he should recognise any of them, and he did not.

And Felix, standing in an alley with blood on his good coat, worked out something that had not occurred to him until that moment: he outranked them.

Not by any authority over enforcers. The Guardsmen Brigade had nothing to do with his department and he had nothing to do with theirs. But the secretary to a Chief Essence Transfer Supervisor sits a long way up a very large guild, and these were patrolmen, and he was, technically and absurdly, senior to every man in the square.

He stepped out of the alley into the open.

“They’re with me.”

It bought nothing immediately. He was a voice in the dark making a claim, and they did not know him from anyone. But they slowed. The two patrolmen fanned out to walk the perimeter, doing the job properly, one towards the back of the stage and one across to the far side.

Then one of them found Theo.

“Boss! Boss, over here!”

The officer did not look round. He had four people at the mouth of an alley with blood to their elbows, and that was the thing that interested him, and he came across the square towards them without breaking stride.

They met in the middle, in front of the empty stage.

“And who are you, then?”

“I am, or was, the secretary of Theo.”

“Who’s Theo?”

“Theodore.” Felix said it evenly. “Of the Guild of Engineers.”

And he watched the man not know the name, and then place the post instead: Chief Essence Transfer Supervisor, a department, a floor of the spire he had no reason to visit. That was the whole trick of it. The guild is enormous, and being unknown inside it is not suspicious, it is normal. Felix used the size of the place, and it worked.

“Right. And who are they?”

“Theo had a speech here. He got shot. They were helping me try and heal him. To no avail.”

Behind the officer, the two patrolmen took Theo by the arms and dragged him. Not carried. Dragged, on his back over the cobbles, heels bouncing, the way you shift something that is in the way of something else. Calder shouted at them to show some respect and a patrolman looked up with the mild irritation of a man interrupted at work.

“Carry on, lads. Don’t worry about them.” The officer stepped closer to Felix, close enough to be a decision. “Look. I’m trying to give you a way out of this, alright? Because you’re a member of the guild. Just between me and you, you can head off. None of this has to be your problem. Let me deal with this lot. Everybody wins.”

“And the people that actually want to help, don’t.” Felix did not move. “That’s not how we’re going to work here.”

“Well. What are you going to do about it?”

He was a tall man with a rifle slung across his back. Lark stepped up beside Felix and touched his arm and said it was alright, sir, that she would cooperate, that she had been at the front and would answer any questions, and that there did not need to be any issue.

“I’m not the one making issues. As far as I’m concerned, you three can come with us.” He looked at the blood on their hands. “You four, if you like. I’m Sergeant Tanner. Guild of Engineers, Guardsmen Brigade. We’re locking down this square on account of there being a crime, and you three have been found tampering with it. We’ll take you back to the spire. Ask you a few questions.”

Then Tanner stopped talking, and put both hands to his head, and screamed.

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Nobody had cast it.

Calder was eight feet away and would have felt anything cast that close, and there was nothing, and no one in the alley mouth had so much as raised a hand. Something reached into Sergeant Tanner's mind from somewhere else in that square and hurt him badly enough to break him off in the middle of a sentence, and it did it in the last second before he took four people into custody.

Tanner staggered fifteen feet, turned, and looked back at them with his hands still at his temples.

"Which one of you did that?"

Then he pulled the rifle off his back and put it on the one who was running.

Billiam was running because he had spent the entire evening being pulled about by strangers and had finally had enough of it, and because nobody in his life had ever given him a reason to stand still in front of guards. Tanner shot him twice in the back with a carbine that fired on essence. Lark threw a hand out towards a boy she had known twenty minutes and the air in front of him lit white where the shot was going to be, a protective field about the size of a dinner plate, arriving exactly late enough to drink most of the first one. The second went into him clean.

He made the alley anyway, and got himself down behind a stack of barrels, and stayed there.

He did not know how badly he was hurt. He put a hand to his side and brought it back up and looked at it in the dark, and there was a long wet graze along his ribs, and his own blood came away on fingers that already had Theo's on them, half dried. Two men's blood on one hand, in one evening, and one of them his.

*Worst day of my life*, he thought, which was true, and which was not going to stay true for very long.

Nobody had decided any of this. A frightened man with a rifle had misread a frightened boy running away from him, and everyone else was standing there when he did.

Then it was a fight, and it was a short one.

The first patrolman came in on Felix with a baton and a shield, and Felix drew a blade of fire out of nothing<sup>3</sup> and swung it up at him in a long bright arc and missed. He would keep missing. That was his entire war: the two of them a yard apart for the whole of it, a sword of fire against a shield, and not once did he get past it.

Calder did not go for anyone. He put two fingers to the base of his own throat

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<sup>3</sup>**Flame Blade.** A sword of fire summoned into the hand and held there. It cuts and it burns, it throws light like a torch, and it lasts as long as the caster keeps hold of it.

and opened his voice out,<sup>4</sup> until it came back off the buildings a half beat behind him, and roared at all three of them that it was none of us, that somebody was framing them, that they were too stupid to see it.

It did not stop anything. It did make the second patrolman hesitate where he stood, and it made Tanner, bent over and bleeding from nowhere, look up and reconsider what exactly he had walked into. Then Calder ran for the alley and put himself between Billiam and the guns, which was not tactics either.

The second patrolman got over it and came in on Lark, and that was the last mistake he made that night. She had the quarterstaff off her back before he reached her. One flat crack across the jaw and he was unconscious before he finished falling. She went straight over the top of him and across the open ground at Tanner, close enough that the rifle was useless, and he had to drop to a baton to keep her off him.

Behind the barrels, ten feet away from all of it, Billiam had got his knife out.

It was a small one. It was not a fighting knife, it was the sort of thing a young man carries because everybody carries one, for rope and bread and getting a lid off, and he had it out in front of him in both hands like a man holding a candle in a wind. He had been shot twice in the back by a guardsman for the crime of running away, and he had known these people for about half an hour, and he had no idea what any of them were.

He risked one look over the top of the barrels.

What he saw was a short Darkin standing in the open square with fire in his hands. A blue one in a good coat fighting a uniformed man with a burning sword. A girl the size of a child moving faster than anybody that size should, putting armoured men on the ground with a stick.

*What is going on. What are these people.*

He got back down behind the barrels and held the little knife with both hands and hoped, very hard, that none of it came near him.

And then there was music.

It came out of the alley itself, right at his shoulder, so that he heard it before anyone else in the square did and never entirely stopped hearing it afterwards. A lute, and it was so good and so completely wrong for that square at that moment that it did the thing nothing else had managed. Tanner stopped. He went glassy-eyed in front of Lark with the baton half raised, and then the baton came out of his hand and hit the cobbles, and he stood there in the middle of a fight listening to it.

Calder was forty feet away and saw all of it.

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<sup>4</sup>**Thaumaturgy.** The first working any apprentice is given. It makes a noise, or a shadow, or a smell of burning, and does nothing else whatever. Calder's goes into his voice.

He put his hand out and scrawled the shape of it on the air,<sup>5</sup> fast and badly, the way you write down a number you are about to lose. His eyes went red. Three of them came off his hand and went across the square like small furious suns, past Lark's shoulder, exactly where he was looking. They came out fire. His always did.

They took Tanner in the chest and lifted him off his feet and put him down, and he did not get up.

*I have killed a man*, Calder thought, and found he had nowhere to put it, and put it down.

Lark turned round from the body and went back to help Felix, who was still a yard from his patrolman and still getting nowhere, and she swung at the man's back and missed him too.

It did not matter. He had watched his sergeant come apart in fire and his mate go down in a single blow, and he broke. He disengaged and ran, and Felix put a knife of ice past his head<sup>6</sup> and it burst on the wall above him, and the man kept going, out of the square and away, with every one of their faces.

\* \* \*

Then it was over, and the four of them were standing in an empty square with two enforcers on the ground, one dead and one not, and no idea at all what had just happened to their evening.

Lark put the quarterstaff away on her back and walked to the body Calder had burned. She bent down and took the carbine off it, and looked at the thing for a second, and then threw it away from her across the cobbles with everything she had.

"What is wrong with them?" She was shouting, and there was nobody left to shout at. "What is *going on*?"

"You. Girl." Calder had got to the alley mouth. "Can you come here? This boy's hurt very badly. I saw you do something with your hands earlier. Maybe you can do it for him too."

Billiam looked up from behind his barrels, bleeding through his shirt, and then looked at Calder.

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<sup>5</sup>**Chromatic Orb.** Three orbs thrown from the hand, each drawn at the moment of casting as cold, acid, lightning, poison, thunder or fire. Calder's come out fire every time, whatever he intends.

<sup>6</sup>**Ice Knife.** A shard of ice thrown at a target, which shatters on arrival and sprays whatever is standing near it.

“Wait. That’s a girl?”

“I don’t know.” Calder considered it. “I assumed.”

Lark, who had been shouting at an empty square ten seconds earlier, looked at the pair of them and found she had nothing to say to that. She came over anyway.

They began to move then, towards each other and towards the mouth of the alley and out.

They were walking away when the man on the ground began to burn.

It started as smoke, which none of them noticed, and then as a smell, which they did. The unconscious patrolman was lying on his back in the middle of the square where Lark had dropped him, and his breastplate had begun to glow: not a reflection, not the lamps, an even dull red spreading out from the centre of the chest across the whole plate. As they watched, it went brighter. He started to move, still unconscious, in the way a body moves when it is being hurt and cannot wake up to do anything about it.

“That’s not me.” Calder had both hands up and away from himself before anybody had looked at him. “That is not me, that’s not on me, I’m not doing anything.”

“I’m not doing anything either,” Felix said.

Lark did not say anything at all. She had the quarterstaff off her back again and she was already running back to him.

She got the end of it under the lip of the breastplate and tried to lever the whole thing off, and it would not come, because it was fastened, and the clasps were the same temperature as the plate. She tried the buckles. She got the staff into the shoulder joint and hauled. There is a point at which the only remaining way to get a piece of red-hot metal off a man is to take hold of it, and Lark got close enough to that point to understand what it would cost, and stood over him with a stick in her hands while he twitched on the stones.

“What is this?” she said. “What is *this*?”

Calder was already looking, and it took him no time at all, because this one he knew.

You take hold of a worked piece of metal and you pour heat into it until it is what it is now,<sup>7</sup> and it is not a difficult working, and it is not a subtle one, and it does not need to be near the thing it is doing it to. It needs one condition and one only. The caster has to be able to see it.

“Someone can see us,” he said. “Right now. Somebody is looking at him right now.”

They all turned round at once, and that was the moment the square stopped

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<sup>7</sup>**Heat Metal.** Exactly what it sounds like, and one of the cruellest things in common use. It needs no contact and no great skill. It needs only that the caster can see the metal.



being a place they had survived and became a place they were standing in.

Nobody was on the rooftops. Nobody was in the mouths of the streets. But Oblong Square is overlooked on all four sides by tenement and shopfront and boarding house, three and four storeys of them, and Felix stood and counted and stopped counting at twenty windows with a clean, level, unobstructed view of the exact spot where a man was cooking inside his own armour. Half of them were dark. Any of them would do.

Somebody had watched the whole fight. Somebody had sat through Theo, and the shot, and the guards, and the killing, and had done nothing at all. And then, when it was finished and four exhausted people were walking away from it, that somebody had reached out and set a man alight on the ground behind them.

"We need to leave," Felix said. "Before whatever this is happens to us."

Calder went and got Billiam up off the ground. The boy was grey and shaking and had stopped being able to make decisions some time ago, and Calder got a shoulder under his arm and told him, in the flattest and most certain voice he could manage, that they were going to the pub now and that it was going to be fine. Billiam let himself be picked up. They went out of the square together like that, the four of them, and behind them the light on the cobbles went slowly from red to nothing.

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Aeska had got there well before them. He had gone round the back and knocked, and Harl had opened the door a hand's width, seen who it was, and pulled him in off the alley by the arm.

"Aeska. What the bloody hell is going on out there?"

He had told him what he could: that Theo had been shot on his own stage, that he was gone, that four people had run towards him instead of away and were still out there, that one of them was the small girl Harl knew. Then he had told him to close everything and be ready for a knock, and that if anyone asked, Aeska was not here.

By the time the other four came through that back door, blood to the elbows, one of them being carried, Harl had the shutters down and the front bolted and was standing behind his own bar looking like a man doing sums he did not like the answers to.

Aeska got up as they came in.

"Well. I told you to leave. You didn't leave. And now look what's happen-"

“First things first.” Calder had Billiam’s weight on his shoulder and did not put him down. “We need to help this guy. He’s been shot. Twice, in the back.” A pause, and then, because it had only just struck him: “I don’t even know your name. But this guy.”

Felix crossed the room, and did not touch him, and healed him from where he stood, a word and a gesture:<sup>8</sup> grey sparks that came off his hand and went and found the two holes in Billiam’s back and knitted them closed. It is a strange thing to watch happen to your own body. Billiam felt the pain go out of him like a held breath, and stood up straighter, and came back to himself for the first time since the square.

“Thank you.” He said it to Felix. “The blue guy. Thank you.” Then he looked around the back room at four strangers. “Who *are* you people?”

Nobody answered that, because nobody had an answer that would have helped.

“Before anything else.” Calder was still on his feet. “Should we not get further away from all this? We’re twenty feet from it. If more of them come, this is the first door they knock on. I know the sewers well enough. We could go down and be gone.”

“Do you have somewhere better?” Aeska said. “Because if you don’t, then this is the best place there is.”

Nobody had anywhere better. That settled it, and Aeska went to the bar.

“Harl. Listen. I know you have a lot of questions right now. But if you keep this quiet, and you don’t tell anybody, and you never mention that any of us were here at all, I will pay your rent for the next month.”

Harl looked at the four of them. Then at the door. Then at Aeska.

“Oh. Um. Right.” He straightened up. “Sure. Whatever you say, Aeska. I mean, I ain’t no friend of the guilds. I ain’t going to be saying anything.” He was already working it through, and warming to it. “Far as I’m concerned it was a misunderstanding. Look, I’ll say it was Below Boys what did it, right. Bit of a tussle with the guards in the square, for whatever reason, and they scampered off down into the tunnels after. If anyone comes asking. Sound good?”

“Good, man. Thank you.”

Ten ducats went across the bar. It is a great deal of money to a man who runs a public house on Oblong Square, and it bought a version of the evening in which none of them had ever set foot in the place.

Lark had not said anything since they came inside. She had gone straight to the front window and got a finger into the gap in the shutters and stayed there,

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<sup>8</sup>**Healing Word.** A healing spoken rather than laid on, which is why it can be done across a room. Quick, and shallow, and enough to put a man back on his feet.

looking out at the square, at the two shapes still lying in it. She did not appear to be crying. She did not appear to be much of anything.

Aeska pulled out a chair, sat down in it, and started asking questions, which was infuriating, and which was also the only reason any of them ever became anything.

“So. Who are you, all of you, and what was your relation to Theo?”

Felix went first, because somebody had to. He gave his name in full, which is long, and said that he had been Theo’s secretary, that he had been standing beside the stage when it happened, and that he had been working for him for the past year.

“A year. That would explain it.” Aeska turned his head. “Next. You.”

“Right. Yes.” Calder was still shaken and it was audible. “I’m Calder. I’ve known him... it’s coming up on five years now. Four or five. Something like that. He was a good friend of mine. He opened a lot of doors for me.”

“Were you also a member of the Guild of Engineers? Or are you still?”

“No. No, I’m not.”

“You’re not. But you knew Theo.”

“Yes. Absolutely.” Calder had had enough of this. “Wait. Before anything else. Who are *you*?”

“We’ll get to that,” Aeska said. “We’ll get to that.”

He looked over at the window. “Girl. Lark, I think Harl said. Come away from there and sit down. People can see you.”

She closed the curtain. Then she came over with her shoulders up round her ears and stood rather than sat.

“Theo was just someone who I admired.” She said most of it to the floor. “And who was there for me at times when I needed someone. We didn’t know each other that well. But he was a good man, and he didn’t deserve any of this.”

“You don’t look the part, but I’ll ask you the same anyway. Were you, or are you, part of the Guild of Engineers?”

“I’m not.”

“Good.” And then, without any change of tone: “You. Over there. The crying one. Stop crying and tell me who you are and why you were at the scene of a crime when it happened.”

“I’m not crying.” Billiam did not come any closer. “And I don’t have to answer you.”

He went to the bar instead and held both hands up to Harl, palms out, filthy to the wrist, and asked whether there was a rag he could have. Harl gave him one. Behind him Aeska put a second healing into his back without asking, and Billiam turned round with the rag in his hands and looked at him.

“My wounds are fine. I just want to clean up. And I don’t have to answer to you. You haven’t even told us your name, and you’re sat there investigating all of us, and you’re the most suspicious man in this room. You’d better start talking, or I’m leaving.”

“As far as I can see, I am the only person here trying to save your skins.”

“As far as *I* can see, you ran away from us.”

There was a pause. Aeska took it, because it was fair.

“Yes. And I will explain myself, if you come and sit down.”

Billiam came a few steps closer. He did not sit.

“My name is Aeska Volan. I am the son of the Volan family. My father is second in command to Dr. Tammerton, and I was trained to be Dr. Tammerton’s next successor. I am now disowned by my family, which is why I am in this position right now.” Nobody said anything, which he took as permission. “When the guards came, I knew they were not there for helpful reasons, seeing as they came with a few when it should have been a whole army. And the officer who was there did not seem interested in Theo at all. Theodore was a really good friend of mine when I was being trained at the guild. It has been two years since I had any contact with him or with anyone there.” He looked round at all four of them. “I plan to find out what happened. I was hoping I could get your help.”

“I will help you with that,” Felix said. Immediately, and without looking up.

Lark had come in closer by then. “Why would they treat him like that?” She put a hand towards the shuttered window, and the square behind it. “Why wouldn’t they treat him with any respect at all? Why would they just *drag* him? Wouldn’t the Guild of Engineers stand behind him? He was theirs.”

“That is the part that tells you something,” Aeska turned a hand over. “Only a handful of guards were sent, where there should have been an army. And the officer who came did not seem interested in Theo at all. Maybe this was planned. Maybe the guard was in on it.”

“He was.”

They all looked round. Billiam had said it flatly, from where he was standing with the rag in his hands, and he did not look away from Aeska when they did.

“I’ve been trying to work out whether it counted. I’m not a guard and I’m not guild and I don’t know what any of that’s supposed to look like from the inside. But I was five feet away when he told him.” A nod at Felix. “When he told that sergeant, out loud, that a man had been shot dead in this square. And he wasn’t surprised.”

“Not surprised,” Felix repeated.

“Not shocked. Not even a bit taken aback. There was no moment where he took it in at all.” Billiam was warming to it now that nobody had told him he was

wrong. "His own man found the body and shouted him over. And he didn't go. He came across the square to us instead, and stood there and let you tell him about a killing like you were telling him the time. And then he wanted it finished. He never asked one question about Theo. Not one, the whole time. He wanted the square shut and somebody in hand and all of it tidied away, and he offered you a quiet way to walk off on your own so there'd be less of it to tidy."

The back room of the Plumb and Bob was very quiet.

"I think he already knew," Billiam said. "Before he ever came into the square."

"Then we agree." Aeska stood up. "I don't know who, and I don't know why. But I plan to find out."

"It was professional." Calder had been quiet a while. "It was clean and it was fast and whoever did it was gone before any of us thought to look up. And then there's the other thing." He was working it out as he said it, which is how he works out most things. "I killed that officer with fire. In the open. And then somebody I never saw cooked a second man on the ground forty feet away and left him lying there. Two burned men in one square, and one of them is mine." He looked round at them. "If somebody wanted a name to hang this on, they have just built one."

"There is also this." Aeska did not soften it. "One of them got out. He ran, and I would assume he recognised you, and that could cause complications." Then, fairly: "Although it was dark. And there were several of you. And both of his friends are lying in the street. We do not know how much of you he actually kept."

While Aeska was still talking, Lark stopped listening to him.

She had been watching Billiam instead. He had not sat down once since they came in, and he was standing at the edge of it all with the rag still in his hands, plainly hating being here, plainly wanting nothing further to do with the man asking all the questions.

She got up and went over, and stood next to him rather than in front of him, and when she spoke she kept it quiet enough that it was only for him.

"I saw that you didn't want to leave him."

Billiam did not answer that.

"I was thinking the same thing," she said. "It just felt dangerous. But I could see that you cared about him a lot."

She left it there, open, not quite a question, which is the only way that sort of thing can be asked.

"I didn't know him that well," he said, eventually. "He's an acquaintance of my father's. He helped me get a job." He turned the rag over. "I don't know him that well. Didn't, I suppose."

"Well." Lark considered it. "Seems like you knew the best of him. Like I did."

“Maybe.”

They stood there a moment longer, the two smallest people in the room, at the edge of a conversation neither of them was part of.

“You can call me Billy, by the way.”

“I’m Lark.”

And that was all of it. He went back to being uncomfortable almost immediately, and she let him, and neither of them said anything else. But it was the first time all night that anybody in that room had told anybody their name without being asked for it.

Aeska was winding up by then. “Whatever else is true, we are here now, and you should all be safe enough for the evening. Rest.” He pushed his chair back in. “I am counting on your help with this.”

He was most of the way to the stairs when Calder caught him.

“Before you leave. I might have some connections. I might know some people I could ask if they know anything about what happened here. I’d need a couple of days.”

“Okay. Well, I too will also try my connections.” Aeska looked at Felix.

“I will ask within the guild.”

They settled on Wexdae, three days out, at the Plumb and Bob.

Aeska took his room upstairs. The other four went out through the back and into the alley and separated there, because they lived in four different directions and none of them had any reason yet to walk together.

It was past midnight. Parvo at that hour is no more dangerous than Parvo at noon, which is to say exactly as dangerous, and they went home across a city that had not noticed anything at all.

Behind them Oblong Square stood empty, with the stalls still up and the goods still out on them, and two men lying in the middle of it, and every window on all four sides of it dark.

In the morning, all four of them had work.